SNOWY RIVER

High wins the climb. Low wins the descent.



2–5 players | 10+ | 20–30 min

"There was movement at the station, for the word had passed around that the colt from old Regret had got away." The best riders chase the wild mob up the mountain. At the top, all but one stop. The weedy pony from the Snowy goes over the edge, and brings them home alone. Every hand rides the poem.

HOW IT WORKS

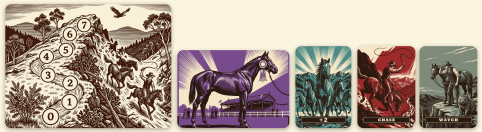
A must-follow trick-taking game with no trumps. One hand per player; the highest total wins.

- **The climb: the highest card wins.** Every trick drives the mob up the mountain.
- **At the summit**, everyone secretly chooses: **Chase** the mob, or **Watch** from the top.
- **The descent: the lowest card wins.** A chaser who wins the most tricks on the way down brings the mob home.

COMPONENTS



- **48 horse cards**: four suits, one for each part of the ride, numbered 1 (a weedy Timor pony) to 12 (a thoroughbred).



- 1 **Mountain** card and a **mob marker** (any small token).
- 1 **Colt from old Regret** card: the mob, worth 3.
- 4 **Brumby** cards, worth +2 each.
- 5 **Chase / Watch** cards, one per player, and a score pad.

EVERY CARD HAS TWO LIVES

A 12 is a big thoroughbred: strong on the climb, useless on the way down. A 1 is a weedy pony: it loses every climb trick and wins the descent. **Choose which cards to spend and which to keep.**

SETUP

1. Put the **Mountain** card in the middle, 0–7 side up (the 0–6 side with 5 players), and the mob marker on the **mimosa clump (0)**. Put the **Colt** card beside it, and the Brumby cards to one side.
2. Everyone takes a **Chase / Watch** card. The player who last rode a horse is the first **dealer**.
3. **Deal** the horse cards as the table shows. The rest stay out, face down and unseen.
4. The player to the dealer's left **leads** the first trick.

Players	Cards each	Left out	Summit at	Hands
2	12	24	7	3
3	12	12	7	3
4	11	4	7	4
5	9	3	6	5

THE CLIMB

The leader plays a card, then each player in turn clockwise plays one, face up.

1. Follow

If you have a card of the **led suit**, you must play one. If you can't, play any card. There are **no trumps**.

2. Highest wins

The **highest card of the led suit** wins. Put the trick face down in front of you: it is worth **1 point**. You lead next.

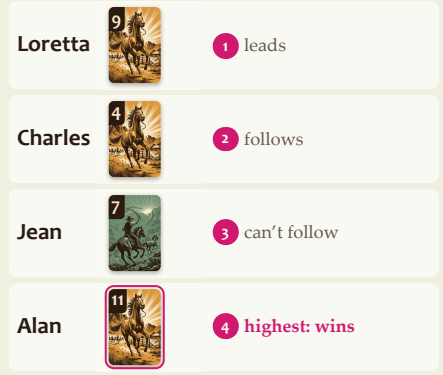
3. The mob climbs

Move the mob marker up the Mountain **1 step**, plus **1 more step for each card** in the trick that wasn't of the led suit.

THEY BREAK AWAY

Each card you can't follow with drives the mob higher. Run out of a suit and you bring the summit closer.

EXAMPLE: A CLIMB TRICK



1 Loretta leads the Escape 9. 2 Charles follows with the 4.

3 Jean has no Escape cards. She keeps her low cards and throws a middling Climb 7.

4 Alan's 11 is the highest Escape: **he wins**.

The mob climbs **2 steps**: 1 for the trick, 1 for Jean's card.

THE SUMMIT

When the mob marker **reaches the summit** (step 7, or step 6 with 5 players), the climb is over after that trick.

Everyone secretly puts their **Chase / Watch** card face down, showing the side they choose, then all reveal at once.

- **Chase:** you go after the mob. The tricks you won on the climb are **at risk**.
- **Watch:** you stop at the top. Your climb tricks are **safe**.

NOBODY CHASES?

"We may bid the mob good day." The hand ends now. The mob escapes: tuck a **Brumby** card under the Colt. Next hand, the mob is worth 2 more.

THE DESCENT

Everyone plays on, **chasers and watchers alike**, until the hands are empty. The winner of the last climb trick leads.

1. Follow

Follow suit if you can, as before.

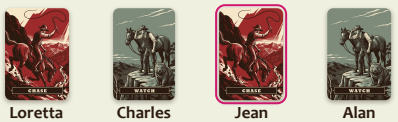
2. Lowest wins

The **lowest card of the led suit** wins. Turn descent tricks **sideways** to keep them apart from your climb tricks. The winner leads next.

WATCHERS ARE THE MOUNTAIN

A watcher can't win the mob, but every descent trick a watcher takes is one a chaser doesn't.

EXAMPLE: THE SUMMIT AND A DESCENT TRICK



Alan		1 leads
Loretta		follows
Charles		2 follows
Jean		3 lowest: wins

Loretta and Jean chase; Charles and Alan watch.

1 Alan won the last climb trick, so he leads the ♣Climb 5.

2 Charles, a watcher, tries to block with the 3.

3 Jean kept her 1 for this: **she wins**.

END OF A HAND

When the hands are empty, find who is **at the mob's heels**: the player who won the **most descent tricks**. If players tie, it is whichever of them won the later trick.

- If they **chased**, they **bring the mob home**: they score the Colt and every Brumby card under it.
- If they **watched**, the mob escapes: tuck a Brumby card under the Colt.

Score the hand

You chose	What happened	You score
Watch	anything	**+1 per climb trick**
Chase	you brought the mob home	**+1 per climb trick + the mob**
Chase	someone else is at the heels	**–1, and climb tricks score 0**

The mob is worth **3**, plus **2 for each Brumby card** under the Colt. There are only 4: once all 4 are there, an escape adds nothing more. Descent tricks score nothing on their own: they only decide who reaches the mob.

After scoring, return any Brumby cards that were brought home. Write the scores on the pad, gather the horse cards, pass the deal left and play the next hand from Setup step 3.

ANY SLIP WAS DEATH

A chaser who doesn't bring the mob home **falls**: their climb tricks are lost and they score **–1**, even if they won no climb tricks at all.

EXAMPLE: THE RECKONING

The mob escaped once earlier, so one Brumby card sits under the Colt: the mob is worth **3 + 2 = 5**. Four descent tricks were played.

	Chose	Climb tricks	Descent tricks	Score
Loretta	Chase	2	0	**–1**
Charles	Watch	2	1	**2**
Jean	Chase	0	3	**5**
Alan	Watch	3	0	**3**

1 Jean won the most descent tricks and chased: she **brings the mob home**. 0 + 5 = **5**.

2 Loretta chased and fell: her 2 climb tricks are lost, and she scores **–1**.

3 Charles and Alan watched: they score their climb tricks, **2** and **3**.

END OF THE GAME

Play **one hand per player** (three hands with 2 players). The **highest total wins**.

Ties: the tied player who brought the mob home most often wins: they are "a household word". Still tied? Share the victory.

AT A GLANCE

- **Every trick:** follow the led suit if you can. No trumps.
- **The climb:** highest wins. The mob climbs 1, plus 1 for each card off the led suit.
- **The summit:** reveal Chase or Watch. Nobody chases: the hand ends.
- **The descent:** lowest wins. Most descent tricks is at the mob's heels.

THE MAN FROM SNOWY RIVER

A. B. "Banjo" Paterson, 1890. Public domain. Three of its thirteen verses.

There was movement at the station, for the word had passed around
That the colt from old Regret had got away,
And had joined the wild bush horses – he was worth a thousand pound,
So all the cracks had gathered to the fray.

…

When they reached the mountain's summit, even Clancy took a pull,
It well might make the boldest hold their breath,
The wild hop scrub grew thickly, and the hidden ground was full
Of wombat holes, and any slip was death.
But the man from Snowy River let the pony have his head,
And he swung his stockwhip round and gave a cheer,
And he raced him down the mountain like a torrent down its bed,
While the others stood and watched in very fear.

…

And he ran them single-handed till their sides were white with foam.
He followed like a bloodhound on their track,
Till they halted cowed and beaten, then he turned their heads for home,
And alone and unassisted brought them back.

THE WORDS

Mob: a herd of horses.
Brumbies: wild bush horses.
Cracks: the best riders.
Stripling: a young lad.
Take a pull: rein in and stop. In the game: Watch.
Let him have his head: give the horse free rein. In the game: Chase.

Game design: Dean Morris · Wombat Game Factory
wombatgamefactory.com
Rule book v3 · 05/11/2026 · Prototype art